



Homecoming: Indian boxer Priya Ghanghas with her family at their residence in Bhiwani, Haryana, during an interaction with *Sportstar*. Weeks after clinching gold in the women's 60kg category at the Asian Boxing Championships in Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, Priya returned home to the people who shaped the journey.

afternoon sun. There is a village called Devsar near Bhiwani, which has a hill, and I used to go running there. It was hard work, but I enjoyed it. Even when I lost, I always had the belief that I needed to work harder. I only thought I needed to work even harder and that there was something wrong with my training," she says.

That hard work would eventually start paying off when Mahendra decided to shift the family to Bhiwani. While Bhiwani was closer to the family village, it is also one of India's primary boxing centres, which Mahendra felt would benefit his children.

It wasn't a simple choice, though.

"Priya was also very good in studies. She scored 90 per cent in her Class 12 board exams. So she could have chosen any path, but she also knew she wanted to focus on boxing," says Mahendra.

Although coach Mahavir says there wasn't anything that initially

stood out about Priya, he soon realised her strengths.

"Boxing isn't purely a physical game. So even if you have one or two excellent qualities and are average in others, you can still become a good boxer. Priya had some technical weaknesses early on. She often dropped her hands while punching, which we had to train out of her.

"But she was also genetically very strong, had a lot of tactical understanding of the sport and very good motor qualities. She has very powerful punches, and she doesn't react badly when she gets punched either. It's a dream quality for any boxer," he says.

What also stood out, Mahavir says, was Priya's obsession with the sport.

"She's always watching videos of boxers. She doesn't just like boxing. She is also constantly learning about the sport. She is a genuine fan of boxing," he says.

Best quality

But perhaps her best quality, Mahavir says, was her stubbornness.

"*Badi diler boxer hai* (She is a very courageous boxer). Her willpower is very strong. She refuses to accept defeat. She keeps pushing herself. A lot of boxers are talented but make excuses. I don't recall a single day when she hasn't shown up to train. I've made her spar against boys and boxers who are far heavier than her, and she never steps back," says Mahavir.

It wasn't just Priya who had an adamant streak. So did her father. Although he ran a stone-crushing business, he made sure to devote as much time as possible to supporting his daughter's training.

"I go to my business one or two days a week at most. But right now my priority is Priya. I take her to the academy and bring her back. When she travels for competitions, I always go with her. When we moved to Bhiwani, I bought a cow and a